

3. STOP BY SCRATCH AND DENT STORES

If you're not especially picky about a tiny scratch, stain, or tear, don't forget to check your local scratch and dent stores for discounted brand-name items. These items often get damaged during shipping, and companies don't necessarily want to sell them right next to their regular offerings.

The great thing about scratch and dent is it gives those of us looking for a great deal a chance to buy almost brand new for less. And who knows, you might find that perfect piece, and no one will probably notice anything wrong with it!

You'll have better luck finding chain store scratch and dents rather than small and family-owned, but it doesn't hurt to call around to see if local furniture or appliance stores have a nearby outlet. You can also visit SearsOutlet.com and ApplianceSmart.com if you're comfortable buying online—just be sure to know your prices beforehand (and check your shipping costs) so you don't overpay.

READER TIP:

IKEA has a big corner near the checkout area with demos and slightly scratched items that go for rock bottom.

—Monique, Netherlands

4. BROWSE YARD AND MOVING SALES

Because most homeowners, including myself, have way too much stuff lying around, yard and moving sales are the perfect place to find new-to-you treasures. Check Craigslist or your local paper for exact times, or go